



**CELEBRATING DEMOCRACY:**  
The first parliamentarians  
photographed in 1956

Rajaji's amendment. Such a gesture is unthinkable now. There has been a steady decline in the number of questions posed and the time spent on discussions. The same cannot be said about the perks. Over half of the MPs have assets of over Rs 50 lakh and more than a quarter have more than Rs 1 crore. Nearly a quarter have criminal cases against them. The lung

power of the multiplicity of political parties represented in Parliament—from five in the first Lok Sabha to nearly 40 in those elected a half-century later—often deprives it of proper discussions on issues of national significance. But Parliamentary practices have acquired a desi touch, with the induction of calling attention notices, short-duration discussions, busi-

ness advisory committees, and committees on assurances.

Despite falling standards, Parliament has been a successful experiment in establishing democratic accountability. Yet one can't but miss the conversational cut-and-thrust of what was once the nation's finest talking shop. Take the case of Pilloo Mody who was once questioned by the Speaker for showing disrespect to the chair by speaking with his back towards him. A rather large Mody defended himself, saying: "Sir, I have neither front, nor back, I am round."

by Shafi Rahman

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PRATAP BHANU MENTA,  
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